

YASBANT NEGI



## Going Club Class

**DELHI** Looks like our members of Parliament have given themselves yet another perk. For the past five years, apart from winning and losing elections, the MPs have also been busy revamping their very own club in the heart of Lutyens' Delhi.

The Constitution Club, which is mostly used for press conferences and seminars, had been in a dilapidated shape for the past 50 years. But now it has been given a Rs 5 crore makeover. The new look includes a

swanky gym, spa, yoga and meditation rooms, not to mention a landscaped garden with an automated drip watering system, complete with Dholpur stone on the outside and Italian marble on the inside. A coffee shop and a restaurant is on the cards for all those fed up with the dreary food in Parliament House. The seminar rooms have been fitted with bay windows.

The initiative for the revamp was taken by the NDA government with the then finance minister

## HIGH LEAGUE: A swanky place for MPs and ex-MPs

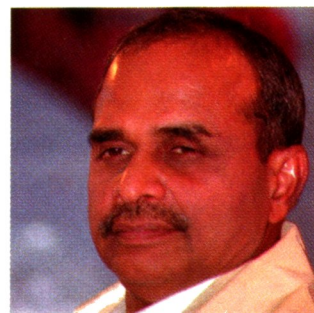
Jaswant Singh making a budgetary allocation for the project. Since then, as much as Rs 3 crore has come from various Union budgets. An upgradation committee that consists of Rajiv Pratap Rudy, K.P. Singh Deo, Hannan Mollah and Sandeep Dikshit is overseeing the makeover; clearly no inter-party politics here. As president of the club, the Speaker is actively involved in the project. The only stumbling block is the club's vice-president and Urban Development Minister Jaipal Reddy who is not too keen on Phase II of the project—revamp of the swimming pool.

"When we took over the project, the club did not even have the mandatory fire-fighting equipment," says Rudy. His excuse for the makeover is that the MPs have very few places where they can take their family members—an explanation that doesn't quite cover the jacuzzi and the pool table.

by Priya Sahgal

## In Destruct Mode

**HYDERABAD** Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy with his outburst at N. Chandrababu Naidu, the leader of the Opposition in the Assembly, taken the term 'unparliamentary language' to newer heights. "I will expose you today. You'll be ashamed that you were born to your mother, you will feel that



**BREATHING FIRE:** Reddy you should not have been born at all," thundered Reddy during a debate in the assembly over the arrest of TDP MLAs and MLCs when they visited the mines of Obulapuram Mining Corp. This was the company which was issued licence on February 18, 2002 by TDP and which, it now alleges, is mining iron ore illegally in Anantapur. Naidu responded calmly, "It's not my culture to pay back in the same coin. The chief minister's words are an insult to all mothers."

TDP leader K. Yerranaidu has appealed to Congress President Sonia Gandhi to pull up Reddy for "insulting motherhood when the party was trumpeting its efforts to empower women". Reddy clarified that he was hurt by the TDP's obstructionist tactics in the Assembly and that he did not insult Naidu's mother.

by Amarnath K. Menon

## OBJECT OF DESIRE

### Talking Point

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